EL NIÑO ACTION BRIEFING · 28 OCTOBER 2026

Salome and the McMullen Valley, Arizona

An El Niño winter here can mean storms that send Centennial Wash through Wenden and cut the roads, and cold nights in RVs and mobile homes. Its deadliest effects may come later, through valley fever, grass fires, and the heat of summer 2027. The first move is a CO alarm in every RV and mobile home, and never driving into a running wash.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
A La Paz County, AZ region (inferred; not resolved)	None published for the US or Arizona	Sep 2026 – Feb 2027 (9-month study: Jun – Feb)	Wash floods and cold nights now; valley fever, fire, and heat in 2027

15/15 recommendations verified. 9 corrected, 0 unverified, 5 contraindicated (the five items under Do not do this, each confirmed as harmful here). Verification corrected several local facts the panel relied on. The Centennial Wash gauge at Wenden alarms at 2.9 ft; 5.45 ft is bank-full. The 2000 evacuation went to Parker High School, not Salome. The dam that failed in 1997 sits downstream of Wenden, so it is not the one to inspect. The Sheriff's Nixle alert feed has been silent for more than six years. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, September 2026, pre-peer-review, heat only, with no figure published for the United States. Heat is not this place's winter hazard, so the historical record carries the risk here. The funding target held at $82,000, but only the food line and WACOG as an organisation could be confirmed; the alarm, heater-repair, and shelter recipients still need a phone call.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



33.78°N 113.61°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** Centennial Wash destroyed more than 40 Wenden homes in 2000 and flooded the town again in the El Niño winter of 2010; in 2008 a Salome woman drowned driving across a flooded wash.
- **For you.** Fit a $25–40 CO alarm in any RV, trailer, or home with gas or propane by 30 November, and never cross a running wash: storms here pass within hours.*
- **The money.** $27,000 floor, $82,000 target, $139,000 ceiling; the cheapest lives saved are CO and smoke alarms in mobile homes and RVs.
- **Do not.** Never run a generator or propane heater inside an RV, cabin, or boat: Arizona lost a family of four to a failed heater in 2018 and three people to a generator in 2025.*

For you, as a resident	9 steps	p. 2
What to do	**10** actions	p. 6
Who does what	RACI chart	p. 14
Where money does the most	funding	p. 14
Do not do this	**5** items	p. 16
What has happened here	the record	p. 17
How this was produced	methodology	p. 19
References	sources	p. 21

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

FOR YOU, AS A RESIDENT 9 STEPS

For a household in Salome, an El Niño winter can bring storms that run the washes and close the roads, and cold nights in RVs and mobile homes. A wet winter can also bring three things next year: valley fever, grass fires in spring, and summer heat. The nearest hospital is in Parker or Wickenburg, so a lot rests on what you do yourself. The ranked actions below are written for the County and its partners. These nine are the ones you can take yourself, at your own cost, grouped by what they protect.

1 · Floods: never drive or walk into a running wash, and plan a way home that crosses none

CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 3

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Now, all winter	$0	Everyone in the car

On 25 August 2008, five Salome women were driving home from bingo in Parker when a dry wash flooded 40–50 yards wide and up to 6 feet deep. Three were swept away, and Eunice Mork, 77, drowned. National Weather Service flash-flood warnings here regularly name Salome, Wenden, Salome Road, and Centennial Wash. Desert storms usually pass within hours, so wait them out on the high side. Under Arizona's "stupid motorist" law (A.R.S. 28-910), a driver who goes round a barricade into a flooded wash can be billed up to $2,000 for the rescue. Look up your own address on the FEMA flood map at msc.fema.gov.*

2 · Carbon monoxide: fit a CO alarm in any RV, trailer, or home with gas or propane by 30 November, and never run a generator or heater inside

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 1

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
30 Nov 2026	About $25–40 per alarm (estimate)	Everyone asleep in a small, sealed space

RVs and older mobile homes are small and tightly sealed, so carbon monoxide builds up fast. On New Year's Day 2018, a family of four died in a cabin in Parks, Arizona, after their gas heating failed. In January 2025, three people died at Saguaro Lake with a generator running inside their houseboat. Run a generator outside, at least 20 feet from doors, windows, and vents. Check the date on any CO alarm already in your RV, because they expire. The Red Cross "Sound the Alarm" program fits smoke alarms free in La Paz County (redcross.org/local/az-nm), but it does not fit CO alarms, so buy those yourself.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

3 · Power: if anyone at home relies on powered medical equipment, file APS's medical form now, and keep a backup battery

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FROM ACTION 7

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
30 Nov 2026	$0 to enroll; about $30–150 for lights and power banks (estimate)	Oxygen, medical devices, phones

Check your bill to see who supplies your power; APS is reported to serve Salome, but this was not confirmed. APS's Medical Care Program needs a form signed by a licensed medical professional (questions: 844-309-5655). Medical-equipment users can also get 35% or 60% off through APS Energy Support. APS will not disconnect customers when the forecast is 32°F or below, a rule kept under its April 2026 settlement with the Attorney General. Report outages on 855-688-2437. No rule protects propane customers, so keep your tank topped up before cold snaps.*

4 · Warmth now, cooling next summer: know where to go on a freezing night, and get your cooler or AC serviced by March

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FROM ACTIONS 4 AND 5

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Warmth plan by 30 Nov 2026; cooling service by 31 Mar 2027	About $100–200 for a service visit (estimate)	Older family members, in cold and in heat

La Paz County publishes no warming center in the McMullen Valley. Project SALT, based in Wickenburg, runs a winter warming station that serves Salome and Wenden; dial 2-1-1 to find what is open. If your home goes cold, heat one small room and agree with a neighbor where you will go. For next summer: in Maricopa County in 2025, mobile homes and RVs were 5% of housing but about 23% of indoor heat deaths. Where an AC unit was present, it was not working in 72% of those deaths. Get your cooler or AC fixed in winter, when contractors are free.

5 · Food: keep two weeks of food that needs no fridge, and know the pantry days in Wenden

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FROM ACTION 9

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

1 Dec 2026	About $100–150 (estimate)	Your household's meals when the roads close

The nearest full supermarket is about 50 miles away, and food arrives on US-60, which crosses Centennial Wash at Wenden. So the weak point is a closed road, not empty shelves. The La Paz County food bank site on Centennial Park Road in Wenden opens Tuesday and Thursday mornings, 8am to noon, for households at or below 185% of the poverty line; bring photo ID and proof of address. Call first, because listings give two phone numbers and two street numbers. St. Mary's Food Bank distributes at Sacred Heart Mission Church in Wenden on the third Wednesday of each month. If you get SNAP, don't miss your DES renewal interview. In Arizona, more than half of denied renewals were for missed interviews.

6 · Water: store more than a gallon per person per day, for two weeks if you can

CONFIRMED ROLE-SPECIFIC

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
30 Nov 2026	About $20–40 for containers (estimate)	Drinking water

Ready.gov advises at least a gallon per person per day, for several days, and two weeks if you can; count pets too. In Salome, store more. In late 2024 the small private Salome Water Company was reported insolvent, with one of its two wells failing, and state regulators considered taking it over. Many homes outside town are on private wells, which stop when the power does.*

7 · Alerts: sign up for the County's "Notify Me" alerts, keep phone emergency alerts switched on, and agree a neighbor check

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED FROM ACTION 6

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
15 Nov 2026	$0	Warning before the water arrives

The La Paz County Sheriff's Nixle feed has sent nothing for more than six years, so don't rely on it. Subscribe through the County's "Notify Me" page (lapaz.gov/list.aspx), and keep Wireless Emergency Alerts switched on in your phone's settings, because flash-flood warnings arrive that way. No NOAA Weather Radio transmitter reliably reaches Salome. 211 Arizona lists La Paz County Emergency Management at 928-669-8753 (County main line 928-669-6115). In an emergency, call 911. If you live in an RV park, give the manager your name and whether you live alone or use oxygen.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

8 · Health: winter shots by mid-November, and from spring 2027, ask for a valley fever test by name if a cough won't go away

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FROM ACTION 10

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Shots by 15 Nov 2026; valley fever watch from Mar 2027	Shots usually $0 if insured	Lungs

The guidance is contested this year, because there are no federal ACIP recommendations for 2026–27. The family physicians (AAFP) and an AMA-led coalition recommend a flu shot for everyone (high-dose or adjuvanted at 65 and over). For COVID they recommend the updated shot, two doses six months apart at 65 and over. For RSV they recommend one dose at 75 and over, or from 50 to 74 with risk factors. Call ahead, because no pharmacy was found in Salome. Valley fever rises after wet winters and hits people aged 75–84 hardest; La Paz had 29 cases in 2024. In Phoenix, 46% of cases were diagnosed more than a month late. If you have a cough, fever, or tiredness that lasts more than a week, ask for a valley fever test by name. The Tri-Valley Medical Center, La Paz Regional Hospital's clinic, is at 39726 Harquahala Road, Salome (928-859-3460).*

9 · Money: buy flood cover before 11 December if you want it, and apply for heating help from 1 December

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED · FROM ACTION 7

BY WHEN	COST TO YOU	PROTECTS
Flood cover before 11 Dec 2026; LIHEAP from 1 Dec	Premium varies; $0 to apply for help	Your home, its contents, and your bills

Unincorporated La Paz County takes part in the federal flood program (NFIP community 040122), so mobile homes and renters' contents can be insured. A new policy takes 30 days to start, and the program is authorized only to 11 December 2026. If it lapses, no new policies or renewals can be issued until Congress acts. Heating help (LIHEAP) in La Paz runs through WACOG, toll-free (877) 829-2264, weekdays 8–5; the heating season is 1 December to 31 March. APS also offers Crisis Bill Assistance of up to $1,000 a year and APS CARE of up to $500.

What to ask of the people in charge

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- Ask **La Paz County Emergency Management** whether the Wenden gauge's 2.9 ft alarm reaches county dispatch, and which building is the shelter for Wenden this winter (action 2).
- Ask **La Paz County Public Works** when Centennial Wash through Wenden was last cleared of brush (action 8).
- Ask the **County** which alert system it uses now, and to retire the dormant Nixle page if it is no longer used (action 6).

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak. Backing lenses are shown per action; an action several lenses reached independently is the stronger bet.

1. By 30 November, fit CO and smoke alarms in about 600 mobile homes and RVs, and check their heaters

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
American Red Cross (Sound the Alarm, Yuma office), with McMullen Valley Fire District and the Tri-Valley Medical Center	30 Nov 2026	About $27,000 for 600 units at ~$45 fitted (estimate)	CO deaths from heaters and generators in small sealed spaces

Between 62% and 69% of Salome's roughly 830 homes are mobile homes, and the winter RV parks along US-60 add many more small, sealed spaces heated by propane. Arizona's recent CO deaths fit this pattern. A family of four died in a Parks cabin on 1 January 2018 after a "significant failure" of its gas heating. Three people died on a houseboat at Saguaro Lake in January 2025 with a generator running inside. After the 2002 North Carolina ice storm, 109 of 124 symptomatic and 25 of 26 severe CO poisonings were in homes with no working alarm (CDC MMWR 53(9)). The Red Cross program, whose specialist covers Yuma and La Paz counties, fits up to four smoke alarms per home free. It does not fit CO alarms, so this action must buy them. The Tri-Valley Medical Center (39726 Harquahala Road) can refer patients.

Transferability: the hazard fits, but no Salome CO death is on record, and the only published cost per death averted ($28,252, Baltimore, Injury Prevention 2014) is for smoke alarms. A 2023 study found state CO-alarm laws had no detectable effect on deaths, which argues for fitting alarms, not mandating them. Corrected in verification: no source shows the fire district fitting alarms; its address and phone

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

come from a 2007 registry record, so confirm by phone before naming it as installer.

2. By 30 November, wire the Wenden gauge's 2.9 ft alarm to county dispatch, pre-sign a shelter, and draw up a door-knock list for the Wenden parks

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
La Paz County Emergency Management, with the Maricopa County Flood Control District and the Red Cross	30 Nov 2026	About $0 for the gauge link (it exists); staff time	Night-time evacuations that start after the water arrives

Maricopa County's ALERT gauge 27507, on the US-60 bridge over Centennial Wash at Wenden, alarms at 2.9 ft. The channel is bank-full at 5.45 ft and in flood at 6.0 ft. On 22 October 2000 the gauge peaked at 7.82 ft (about 24,250 cfs) before dawn: more than 40 Wenden homes were destroyed, about 500 people were evacuated, and about half were bused to Parker High School. In January 2010, during an El Niño winter, Wenden flooded again and residents went to higher ground in Salome. Route the 2.9 ft alarm to county dispatch so that the evacuation call is made on a gauge reading, sign a shelter agreement with a building in Salome, and walk a door-knock list for the Wenden RV and mobile-home parks before the first storm.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: local precedent. Corrected in verification: 5.45 ft is bank-full, not the alarm level. The 2000 shelter was Parker High School, not Salome High School. A "second surge" in 2010 could not be sourced and was dropped. The County's emergency-management phone comes from 211 Arizona, not a County page.

3. By 1 December, stage barricades at the low-water crossings, and hand out wash-crossing maps to every RV park and desert-lot road

CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · SKEPTIC · PUBLIC HEALTH · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
La Paz County Public Works (roads), with ADOT for US-60 and volunteers for the maps	1 Dec 2026	Existing barricades; about $150 to print door hangers	Drownings in vehicles, the way people have died here

Salome's best-documented weather death came on an ordinary evening drive. On 25 August 2008, Eunice Mork, 77, drowned when a dry wash flooded 40–50 yards wide and up to 6 feet deep on the way home from Parker. In January 2010, the El Niño floods killed people in vehicles elsewhere in Arizona, including a teenager in Phoenix and a 6-year-old swept away in Yavapai County. Stage barricades at the US-60 crossing of Centennial Wash, Salome Road, and Eagle Eye Road, and close them rather than rely on signs. Volunteers mark the crossings each RV park and desert-lot road depends on, and leave a "turn around" door hanger.

Transferability: local. The barricade sites were not checked against a County road list. Corrected in verification: A.R.S. 28-910 lets agencies bill up to $2,000 for a rescue; the claim that it is "rarely enforced" was not sourced and was dropped.

4. Over the winter, repair coolers and air conditioners in mobile homes and RVs, before the heat of May 2027

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
WACOG (weatherization and LIHEAP cooling), with private contractors	31 Mar 2027	$30,000 for about 20 repairs at ~$1,500 (estimate)	Indoor heat deaths in summer 2027

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The El Niño's largest toll here may not come this winter. In Maricopa County's 2025 heat report, mobile homes (12%) and RVs or trailers (11%) together accounted for about 23% of indoor heat deaths, against 5% of housing. An AC unit was present in 94% of indoor deaths, and in 72% of those it was not working. 90% of the victims were aged 50 or over, and Salome's median age is about 71. A meta-analysis of heat-wave deaths found a working home air conditioner cut the odds of death by about three-quarters (OR 0.23; Bouchama et al., 2007). Fix the units now, while contractors are free.

Transferability: the death data are from Maricopa, not La Paz, and the meta-analysis pooled studies from Europe and the US. Corrected in verification: "72%" is the share of AC units that were not working, not the share of victims over 65. Whether WACOG's weatherization program repairs coolers, and how long its waitlist is, could not be confirmed.

5. By 30 November, recruit a storm captain in each RV park, with a paper list of residents who live alone or use oxygen, to check on them after storms now and on heat days in 2027

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
RV park managers, with volunteers and the Centennial Public Library	30 Nov 2026	Volunteer time	Isolated people found too late, in cold or in heat

The winter population swells with visitors who are on no county list, clustered in parks along US-60: Black Rock RV Village, Indian Hills RV Resort, Dreamers RV Park, Desert Palms (55+), Salome KOA, and Wagon West (55+). In Maricopa County in 2025, 48% of indoor heat deaths were found on a welfare check, often too late. Social contact cut the odds of dying in a heat wave by more than half in the same meta-analysis (OR 0.40). Each captain keeps a paper list, checks on those residents after storms and outages, and keeps the list running into summer.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the effect is from heat, not cold, so its use for winter is an extrapolation. The parks were confirmed from third-party listings, not park websites. The library's hours and address were not confirmed.

6. By 15 November, get residents onto alerts that actually work, and retire the dormant Nixle page

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
La Paz County (Emergency Management and the Sheriff's Office), with volunteers	15 Nov 2026	About $0	Warnings that reach no one

Four lenses pointed residents to the Sheriff's Nixle alerts (text the ZIP code to 888777). Verification found the feed's newest alert is about six years and eight months old. The County site names no CodeRED, Everbridge, or Genasys system, only a "Notify Me" subscription page, and no NOAA Weather Radio transmitter reliably reaches Salome. Run sign-up tables at the library, the pantry days, and the RV parks, in English and Spanish. Enrol people in "Notify Me", and check that Wireless Emergency Alerts are switched on in their phones. The County should either revive Nixle or take the page down.

Corrected in verification: Nixle is dormant, so it was removed as a recommendation. Wenden's families are largely Spanish-speaking (Hispanic share estimates run 43–66%), so Spanish material is essential.

7. By 30 November, enrol medically dependent households with APS, and from 1 December get eligible households onto heating help

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
WACOG (LIHEAP), with APS and the Tri-Valley Medical Center	30 Nov 2026; LIHEAP from 1 Dec	$0 public for enrolment; benefits paid by APS ratepayers and LIHEAP	Cold homes and shut-off medical equipment

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The one pre-arranged trigger here is APS's rule that it will not disconnect customers when the forecast is 32°F or below. The April 2026 $7 million settlement with the Attorney General keeps that rule in place; APS denies the allegations. APS also offers a Medical Care Program, 35% or 60% off for medical-equipment users, Crisis Bill Assistance up to $1,000 a year, and APS CARE up to $500. Heating help (LIHEAP) for La Paz runs through WACOG, toll-free (877) 829-2264. The heating season is 1 December to 31 March. LIHEAP is funded this year, though the FY27 budget again proposes ending it. No rule protects propane customers from losing deliveries.

Corrected in verification: APS CARE pays up to $500, not $1,000. That APS serves Salome is supported only by aggregator sites, so households should check their bill. The other WACOG numbers the panel gave could not be confirmed and were dropped.

8. By 15 December, clear brush from Centennial Wash through Wenden, as was done after the 2010 flood, and ask owners of upstream earthen dams to inspect them

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
La Paz County Public Works, with the City of Phoenix and the US Army Corps of Engineers (landowners along the wash)	15 Dec 2026	County crews; no published figure	The wash leaving its banks into Wenden

After the 2010 flood, the County supervisor got the City of Phoenix and the Army Corps to clear their stretches of the wash, and County Public Works cleared the rest. Brush had clogged the channel. That was 15 years ago, and the gauge notes still describe the channel at Wenden as "heavily vegetated". In the remnants of Hurricane Nora in September 1997 (a strong El Niño year), 11.97 inches of rain fell on Harquahala Mountain, and many earthen dams in the watershed breached. Ask the owners of the earthen dams upstream of Wenden to inspect them for piping before the first winter storm.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrected in verification: the Narrows Dam, which failed by piping in 1997, sits about 5 miles southeast of Salome, downstream of Wenden, so it is not the dam to name. An "Upper Centennial Control Structure" could not be found and was dropped. The 2011 clearing rests on one local news source.

9. By 16 December, stock two weeks of shelf-stable food at the Wenden pantry, and help SNAP households through their renewal interviews

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FOOD SUPPLY CHAIN · PHILANTHROPIST · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
St. Mary's Food Bank and the La Paz County food bank site in Wenden, with Arizona DES and the Arizona Food Bank Network	16 Dec 2026 (before the third-Wednesday distribution)	$10,000 for shelf-stable boxes	Hunger when US-60 or local roads close, and benefit loss over paperwork

The El Niño signal in food here is weak. Wet El Niño winters did cut Yuma lettuce supply in 2010 and January 2016, but those price spikes last weeks. The real risks are a road cut by a flooded wash and the loss of SNAP. Arizona has cut about 500,000 people from SNAP, a 55% drop in a year. DES dropped 3.09 million calls, and 53.7% of denied renewals were for interviews never completed. Stock boxes at the Centennial Park Road site in Wenden (Tuesday and Thursday, 8am to noon) and at St. Mary's monthly distribution at Sacred Heart Mission Church. Turn the planned "work-rule clinic" into help completing DES interviews.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Corrected in verification: the work rules took effect at the start of 2026, but missed interviews now cost more people their benefits. The Bicentennial Union High School District pantry and any WACOG meal route in Salome could not be confirmed.

10. Before spring 2027, alert clinicians to test for valley fever, and mow cured grass near homes in March and April

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · SKEPTIC | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NOT CONSULTED

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Arizona Department of Health Services and La Paz County Health, with the Tri-Valley Medical Center and La Paz Regional Hospital	Alert by 1 Mar 2027; mowing March–April 2027	Staff time; residents' own time for mowing	Late-diagnosed valley fever, and grass fires reaching homes

A wet winter grows grass, and when it dries the spores and the fuel follow ("grow and blow"). La Paz had 29 valley fever cases in 2024 (169.3 per 100,000), and statewide rates peak at ages 75–84. In Phoenix, 46% of cases were diagnosed more than a month late (Ginn et al., 2019), and two health systems tested only 2% and 13% of outpatients with pneumonia (Chang et al., 2008). After the wet winter of 2004–05, the Cave Creek Complex fire burned about 244,000 acres of grass-loaded desert in June 2005. Ask clinicians to test every community-acquired pneumonia for cocci, and tell residents to cut grass within 30 feet of homes and vehicles once it cures.

Transferability: no study shows that a testing alert lowers deaths; it shortens delay. ADHS notes part of the 2024 rise came from false-positive results. The timing between a wet winter and rising cases is uncertain, so the alert should run through 2027.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	La Paz County EM	La Paz County Public Works	ADOT	Maricopa County FCD	Red Cross	McMullen Valley Fire District	WACOG	APS	RV park managers & volunteers	Food banks	Health (ADHS, County, clinic)
1. CO and smoke alarms	I	–	–	–	A/R	R	–	–	C	–	C
2. Gauge, shelter, door-knock list	A/R	C	–	R	R	R	–	–	C	–	–
3. Crossing barricades and maps	C	A/R	R	–	–	I	–	–	R	–	–
4. Cooler and AC repair	–	–	–	–	–	–	A/R	C	C	–	I
5. Storm captains	C	–	–	–	C	I	–	–	A/R	–	I
6. Working alerts	A/R	–	–	–	–	C	–	–	R	–	–
7. APS medical and LIHEAP	–	–	–	–	–	–	A/R	R	C	–	R
8. Wash clearing and dam checks	C	A/R	–	C	–	–	–	–	–	–	–
9. Pantry stock and SNAP interviews	I	–	–	–	–	–	C	–	R	A/R	–
10. Valley fever alert and mowing	I	–	–	–	–	C	–	–	R	–	A/R

What the chart shows: no single body is accountable for more than two rows. RV park managers and volunteers do work on seven, because they reach the winter visitors no county list holds. Rows 2, 3, 6, and 8 need a decision and staff time, not new money.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this place can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR

$27,000: the alarms alone

TARGET

$82,000: the sum of the four placements

CEILING

About $139,000

LARGEST UNCERTAINTY

How many RV and mobile-home units are occupied this winter; no one publishes it

Target: $27,000 (600 alarm sets × $45) + $30,000 (20 heater or cooler repairs × $1,500) + $15,000 (shelter readiness: 100 cots × $60, a $5,000 generator, $4,000 of blankets and supplies) + $10,000 (pantry stock) = $82,000. Ceiling: the target plus a second $27,000 of alarms for the winter RV parks and another $30,000 of repairs = $139,000. Beyond that, the local groups cannot spend more before the peak. Every unit

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

cost is an estimate, not a quote. Verification left the target unchanged, but only the food line and WACOG as an organisation could be confirmed. Phone the fire district, WACOG, and the school district before releasing money.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Red Cross Sound the Alarm (Yuma office), with McMullen Valley Fire District	Action 1: CO alarms bought for mobile homes and RVs; smoke alarms fitted free by the Red Cross	$27,000	Direct grant	$28,252 per death averted for smoke alarms, Baltimore (Injury Prevention 2014); no CO-alarm equivalent; a 2017 study found CO alarms pay off only if they prevent more than 10% of poisonings	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
WACOG	Actions 4 and 7: emergency heater repair now, cooler and AC repair before May	$30,000	Top-up to an existing scheme	20 × $1,500 (estimate); working AC OR 0.23 for heat-wave death (Bouchama 2007)	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
A Salome shelter site (Bicentennial Union High School District or a church), or Project SALT's warming station	Action 2: cots, generator, and supplies for the flood and cold shelter	$15,000	Pre-positioned stock	Line-item arithmetic; the 2000 evacuation needed transport to Parker	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
St. Mary's Food Bank (Wenden) and the La Paz County food bank site on Centennial Park Road	Action 9: shelf-stable boxes ahead of road closures	$10,000	Pre-positioned stock	About two weeks for 150 households; lowest return in lives of the four	CONFIRMED

The funder's one thing: the 2010 flood was frightening and visible, and no one in Wenden died in it. The deaths here are more likely to be quiet ones: carbon monoxide this winter, then valley fever and heat in 2027. La Paz had the highest valley fever hospital occupancy per head in Arizona in 2021. So the alarms and the cooling repairs come before flood equipment.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

Advice that circulates for this hazard and would cost lives here.

Running a generator or a propane heater inside an RV, trailer, cabin, or boat, or telling people to "use a backup heater" without a CO alarm *

CONTRAINDICATED

Small, sealed spaces fill with carbon monoxide fastest. Arizona's recent cases were a family of four in a Parks cabin whose gas heating failed (2018), and three people on a Saguaro Lake houseboat with a generator running inside (2025). Older and converted RVs often have alarms that have expired or been disabled.

Instead: run a generator outside, at least 20 feet from doors, windows, and vents. Pair every heating message with a battery CO alarm, and check its expiry date.

Driving or walking across a running wash

CONTRAINDICATED

This is how Eunice Mork of Salome died in August 2008, in a wash that had been dry an hour before. Desert floods arrive as a wall of water, and the depth can't be judged from the bank.

Instead: wait. Storms here pass within hours. Know a route home that crosses no wash, and never go round a barricade.

Sandbags as a household defense against Centennial Wash

CONTRAINDICATED

The gauge notes describe a channel that is "very flat and very wide" and spreads its flow sideways. Sheet flow like that goes round sandbags, and filling them takes time and strength that older residents would do better to spend leaving.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: move vehicles, papers, and medicines to high ground early, and leave when the gauge alarm or a flash-flood warning comes.*

Spending money in advance on the assumption that El Niño guarantees a wet winter

CONTRAINDICATED

This El Niño is record-strong, with better than an 83% chance it stays strong through January–March 2027, and NOAA tilts Arizona toward above-normal rain. That is better odds, not a guarantee. In the strong 2015–16 El Niño, storms stayed north and much of Arizona was drier than normal. And Wenden's two "100-year" floods came in opposite phases, La Niña in 2000 and El Niño in 2010.

Instead: spend first on measures that pay off in a wet or a dry winter: CO alarms, working alerts, crossing barricades, cooler repair, and the gauge link.

Telling Salome residents to "go to a warming or cooling center" as if one exists nearby

CONTRAINDICATED

La Paz County publishes no warming or cooling center in the McMullen Valley. The County offices are in Parker, about 55 miles away, and many older residents and winter visitors don't drive at night. Advice that points to a place no one can reach leaves people at home without a plan.

Instead: check on people where they live, through the RV park storm captains. Name the real options: Project SALT's warming station, which 211 lists as serving Salome and Wenden, and a heated neighbor's home.

WHAT HAS HAPPENED HERE BEFORE — THE RECORD

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Sep 1997	Remnants of Hurricane Nora, strong El Niño (ONI +2.0): 11.97 in on Harquahala Mountain	Many earthen dams breached; the Narrows Dam, downstream of Wenden, failed by piping	Not checked

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
Oct 2000	Centennial Wash leaves its banks before dawn, La Niña (ONI −0.5): gauge 7.82 ft, about 24,250 cfs	More than 40 Wenden homes destroyed; about 500 evacuated, about half bused to Parker High School	Federal disaster FEMA-1347-DR (individual and public assistance); no record of buyouts or elevations
2005	Wet El Niño winter, then a big grass crop (regional)	Cave Creek Complex fire burned about 244,000 acres in June, in Maricopa County	Fire managers warned of "more fire in the desert than in the timber"
Aug 2008	Monsoon flash flood in a dry wash on the drive home from Parker	Eunice Mork, 77, of Salome, drowned; four others survived	Nothing recorded
Jan 2010	El Niño storms (ONI +1.5): Wenden floods again	Residents moved to higher ground in Salome; no deaths reported in Wenden	Federal disaster FEMA-1888-DR (public assistance only), declared two months later; the wash was cleared in 2011
2024	Valley fever in La Paz County	29 cases, 169.3 per 100,000	None
Dec 2024	Salome Water Company reported insolvent, one of two wells failing	None reported	State regulators considered a takeover

The recurrence nobody has noticed: Wenden's two "100-year" floods came ten years apart and in opposite ENSO phases. The driver in this valley is a wide, flat, overgrown channel with mobile homes beside it, more than the El Niño label. The only fix on record is brush clearing, done after the flood, and that was 15 years ago.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — UNRESOLVED

- **"El Niño makes this a flood winter"** (emergency manager) versus **"the wet forecast can bust"** (skeptic). NOAA gives better-than-even odds, the 2010 El Niño flooded Wenden, and the strong 2015–16 El Niño was dry. Every action here is chosen to pay off either way.
- **"Most of this El Niño's deaths will come in 2027"** (public health: valley fever and heat) versus **"the danger is this winter's storms and cold"** (emergency manager). A death count in a place this small will never settle it. ADHS itself warns that random error in La Paz figures "may be substantial". Judge success by units repaired and people reached.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **"Alarms and clinics before flood gear"** (philanthropist) versus **"gauge, barricades, and wash clearing"** (emergency manager, historian). The flood measures mostly need decisions, not money, so both can go ahead.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

No lens could count the people at greatest risk: winter visitors in RVs, who are on no county list, and households on off-grid desert lots past a wash. No lens could say what ambulance cover the McMullen Valley has, or how long a call takes to reach Parker or Wickenburg. The Colorado River Indian Tribes, based in Parker, were not covered.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Eight simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people. They are not neighbourhood figures. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; drought, flood, fire, smoke, and crop failure are additional to it and are carried here by the historical record rather than by a published number.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED — METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named Salome, AZ. It was built for Salome together with the McMullen Valley communities that share its road, its wash, and its services: Wenden, Harcuvar, and Hope. Salome CDP has about 730 people (ACS via aggregators, not Census tables), and La Paz County is one of Arizona's oldest, with a median age near 60. Climate Impact Lab impact region, as this report records it: a La Paz County, AZ region, inferred rather than resolved on the Impact Map; La Paz has only about 16,500 people, so it may be merged with a neighbour. Mortality figures exist only at that scale (impact regions average roughly 300,000 people); local detail is used for hazard exposure and action design, not for death counts.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Where heat is not the dominant hazard, the historical record carries the hazard instead of a borrowed number.

- **Expert panel.** Eight simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, philanthropist, and food supply chain analyst) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Six verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. Food actions were checked for data frequency and timing. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed.
- **Who does what.** The RACI chart is built from the owners named in the verified actions, with one accountable party per action. It is a proposal: no organisation named in it has been contacted or has agreed to a role.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.
- **Adaptation Inventory.** Not consulted in this run. The inventory is a client-side tool that needs its dataset downloaded, and that was not done, so no action here should be read as having "no precedent".
- **Reader.** No role was given, so the For you section is written for a resident. Its nine steps were taken from the verified actions and from a separate check of household guidance for Salome (alert systems, utility and water contacts, warming options, the flood program, vaccine guidance, and the local clinic), on the same three tests. The rest of the report is written for La Paz County and its partners.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (carbon monoxide, generators, flooded washes, medical equipment in an outage, emergency water, vaccines, and when to call 911) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so and shows the containing geography's number with its arithmetic. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in this place was interviewed. The impact region was not resolved on the Impact Map. Several facts could be confirmed only indirectly. The County emergency-management phone comes from 211 Arizona, not a County page. That APS serves Salome comes from aggregator sites. The fire district's address and phone come from a 2007 registry record. The 2010 Wenden evacuation is described only by an encyclopedia entry, and the 2014 Norbert flooding could not be confirmed for this place. Pantry phone numbers conflict, so none is printed. The OpenFEMA policy API returned an error, so no flood-policy count is given. Unit costs for alarms, repairs, and shelter supplies are estimates.

References · Confirmed or corrected in verification: Maricopa County FCD, gauge 27507 (Centennial Wash at Wenden) · gauge 27507 station description · FCDMC, Hurricane Nora report · FEMA-1347-DR (2000) · Herald, Wenden evacuation, 23 Oct 2000 · FEMA-1888-DR (2010) · FEMA-1888-DR damage assessment · Parker Pioneer, Centennial Wash clean-up · Wenden, Arizona · January 2010 Arizona storm deaths · 2008 Salome wash drowning · NOAA ONI · CDC MMWR 53(9) · Injury Prevention 2014 · Red Cross Arizona, home fire campaign · AZFamily, Saguaro Lake CO deaths · KSL, Parks cabin deaths · Tri-Valley Medical Center (NPI) · APS assistance programs · APS Medical Care Program · APS contacts · APS settlement, April 2026 · 211 Arizona, WACOG La Paz intake · LIHEAP Clearinghouse, Arizona seasons · APPA, LIHEAP funding · CRS, NFIP authorization · FEMA Community Status Book, Arizona · Maricopa County 2025 Annual Heat Report · Bouchama et al. 2007 · ADHS valley fever 2024 · Ginn et al., EID 2019 · Chang et al., EID 2008 · CLIMAS, "Will April rains bring May flames?" · Cave Creek Complex fire · KJZZ, El Niño and Arizona's winter · CLIMAS, March 2016 outlook · Nixle, La Paz County Sheriff (dormant) · La Paz County "Notify Me" · NWS Phoenix, weather radio · KJZZ, Salome Water Company · AAFP 2026 adult respiratory vaccines · Wenden food resources · St. Mary's Wenden distribution · Project SALT warming station · KJZZ, Arizona SNAP interviews · University of Arizona, 2010 vegetable advisory · Data USA, Salome · Ready.gov, water · FloodSmart. Not confirmed and not used: an "Upper Centennial Control Structure", a 2010 "second surge", the 2014 Norbert flooding in this valley, and the Nixle feed as a live system.
Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory
Generated 28 October 2026 for Salome and the McMullen Valley, La Paz County, Arizona. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.